helpful for our friends now," dictated Khrushchev. "Then let them state that openly, and we will have to make conclusions for ourselves."

The message was clear. If Castro did not reverse his order and his soldiers actually began shooting at American airplanes, then not only would the Soviets not follow in his footsteps, as had happened inadvertently on October 28, but Khrushchev would withdraw his troops from the island, leaving Castro and his comrades to face Kennedy alone. A guarantee that there would be no American invasion remained Khrushchev's main goal in resolving the Cuban crisis, and he made one last attempt to convince Castro to fall into line. Mikoyan was instructed to remind Castro of three possible scenarios for inspection: through the UN, Latin American ambassadors, or representatives of ten neutral countries. Castro had earlier rejected all those options, but after the Presidium meeting ended, one of the participants convinced Khrushchev to reintroduce them. It was a long, long shot. Khrushchev advised Mikoyan to leave if he thought there was no hope of agreement but to stay if there was any possibility of progress.[16]

Khrushchev paused in his correspondence with Kennedy. He was playing for time, hoping that Mikoyan would convince Castro not only to agree to the withdrawal of the bombers in exchange for the lifting of the blockade but also to accept some form of UN inspection that would clear the way for an American pledge not to invade Cuba. Reports from Cuba suggested that there was still time to negotiate. Mikoyan informed him on November 18 that Castro's decision to open fire had been emotional, and that he had admitted to Mikoyan that all he wanted was to stop the low-level flights: he had resigned himself to the high-level ones. Since the Americans had put a stop to low-level flights as of November 16, Mikoyan saw no imminent danger of conflict and war.[17]

In Havana, Sunday, November 18, the day on which the Cubans were to start shooting at American airplanes, passed without antiaircraft fire: there were no more low-level flights, and Castro could do nothing about the continuing U-2 overflights. In his letter of November 15 to U Thant, he had written that the Cubans would destroy airplanes violating their airspace "to the extent of the firepower of our antiaircraft weapons." The limit appeared to have been reached very quickly. On November 17, Malinovsky reported to the Central Committee that he had prohibited Pliev from "opening fire on